Buddha's life, such as Bodh Gaya, Sarnath, Vaisali and Kushinagar, met many teachers 'renowned for their brilliant character', and was glad for 'the opportunity of acquiring knowledge from them personally'. Yijing's extensive account of monastic life in India reveals him as a devout yet pragmatic man, full of the sort of courage that's fuelled by religious zeal, and obsessed with codes of monastic conduct. When leaving India in 685 CE, he carted home 400 books and translated many of them on a second, multi-year stint in Sumatra. Aided by a few Indian monks, he continued this work in China, translating fifty-six works in 230 volumes. He died at the age of seventy-nine, and, like Xuanzang, was lavishly honoured by the Tang emperor.

On Interpreting Their Words

How should we read the records of Faxian, Xuanzang and Yijing? Their impressions of India are fragmentary, subjective and prone to biases and vagaries of their psychological dispositions. As with all travellers, parts of their testimonies derived from hearsay, cultural misunderstandings, personal blinders, or ideas simply 'lost in translation'.

All three monks had deep religious commitments even as they were all very curious. They often relate magical events, supernatural beings and moralistic legends without scepticism, posing challenges of interpretation for the modern scholar. For instance, Xuanzang's Buddha has subdued dragons, flown in the air, turned into a serpent to deliver magical cures and fed his blood to yakshas in a previous life; we read about a tooth relic of the Buddha that emits a bright light on religious days, and a monkey who has accrued enough 'religious merit' to be reborn as a man. Certain stupas with (purported?) relics of the Buddha, such as hair or nails, are described as having magical healing properties. Bodhisattvas appear above the ocean skies to rescue people from shipwrecks. It is reported matter-of-factly that in a forest lived a 700-year-old Brahmin who looked like he was thirty.

All three pilgrims wrote from memory, sometimes years later, raising the odds of error and embellishment. At times, the traveller narrated his story to a local scholar monk who then wrote it down. Moreover, their target audience was 'one that they had hoped would see them as highly erudite, knowledgeable because they had been there, so to speak, in the place where